

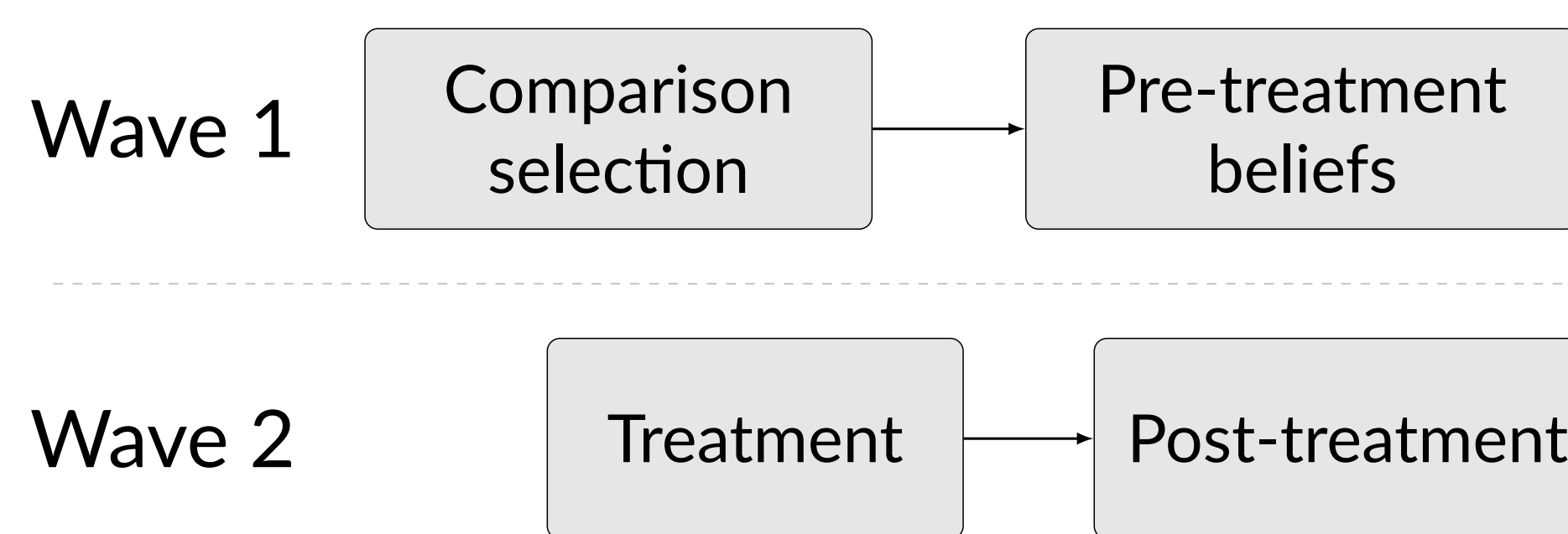


Summary

- How do voters interpret incumbent performance measures?
- Electoral accountability difficult with noisy information
 - Hard to disentangle state-of-the-world shocks and incumbent effort
- Evidence for providing information affecting voting outcomes mixed
- How do voters process information differently based on how the information is benchmarked?
- Findings:
 - People choose benchmarks that are intuitive
 - Benchmarking is crucial for information to affect vote intentions

Two-Wave Survey Design

- Two-wave survey fielded in Mexican states holding local elections
- Descriptive benchmark analysis and experimental analysis

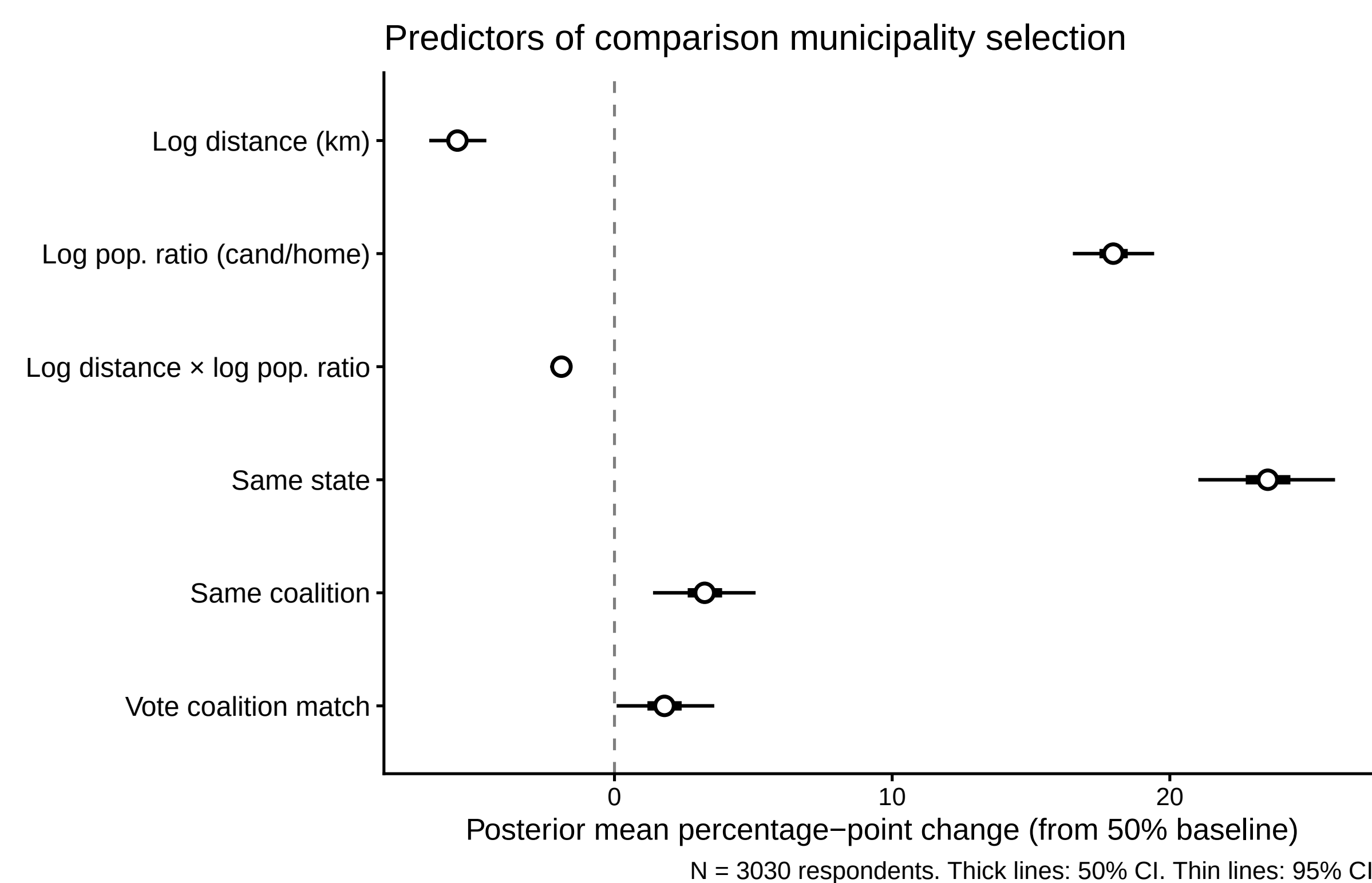


Descriptive Analysis of Comparison Municipalities

- Choose best comparison from list of candidate munis pre-treatment
- 15 candidates drawn from three pools: geographically near, nation-wide largest population, random
- Bayesian hierarchical model with respondent random intercept
- Controls for candidate muni menu, home muni characteristics

Chosen Comparison Municipality Results

- Geographical proximity variables strongest predictor
- Large municipalities more likely to be chosen
- Political party variables less strongly correlated but significant
- Better known municipalities make better comparisons



Experimental Analysis with Varying Benchmarks

- Provide real crime information to survey respondents, estimate effect of information on incumbent evaluations

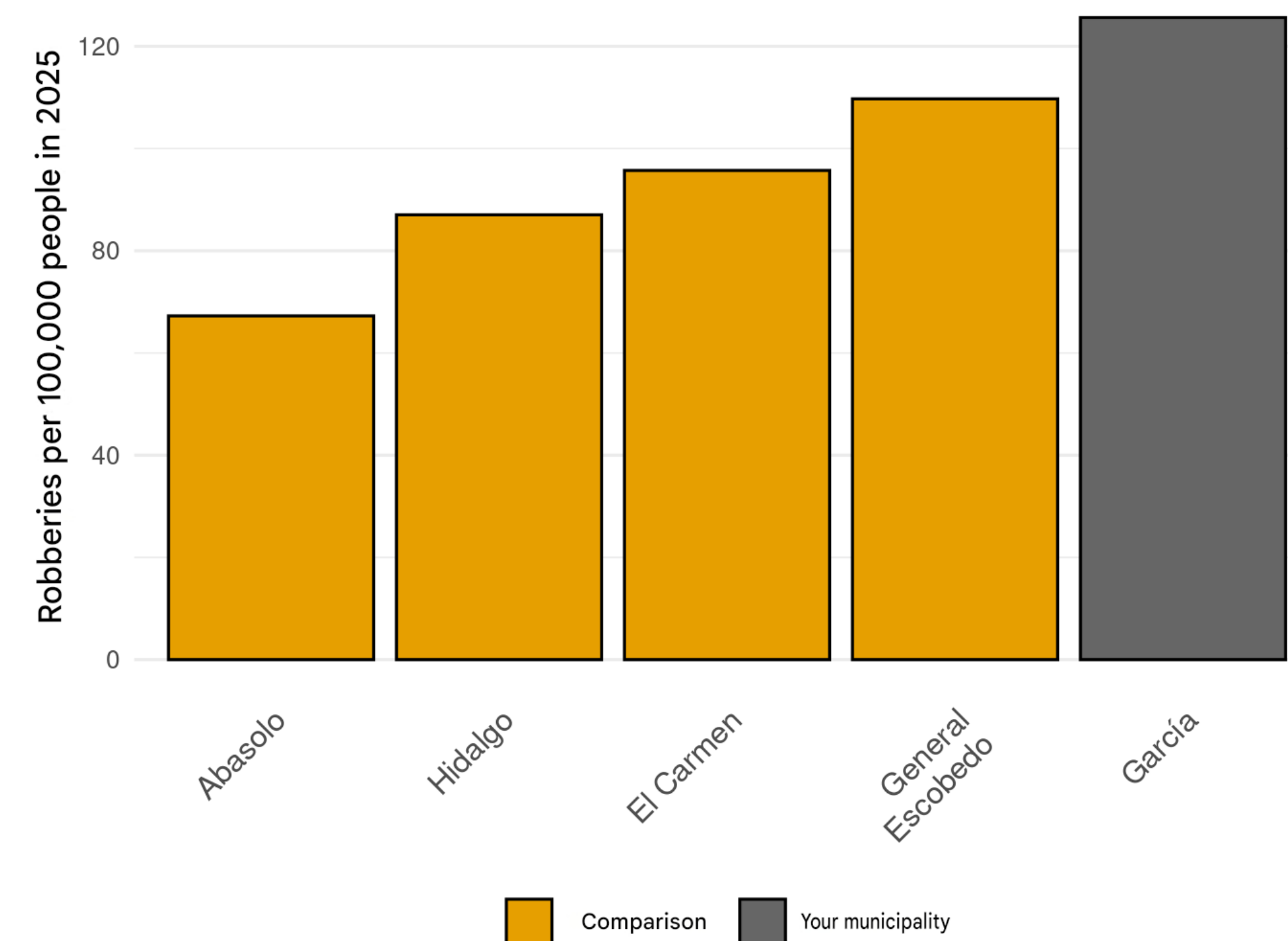
Arm	Comparison shown	Party labels
Control (Weather Information)	None (home only)	No
T1 Own Crime Rate	None (home only)	No
T2 Non-partisan Benchmark	Similar muni	No
T3 Opposition Benchmark	Out-coalition muni	Yes
T4 Co-Partisan Benchmark	Same-coalition muni	Yes

- Outcome: post-treatment incumbent vote intention for upcoming local elections

$$y_i = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 CG_i + \alpha_2 RG_i + \sum_{k=1}^4 \delta_k T_{ik} + \sum_{k=1}^4 \beta_k (CG_i \times T_{ik}) + \sum_{k=1}^4 \gamma_k (RG_i \times T_{ik}) + \varepsilon_i$$

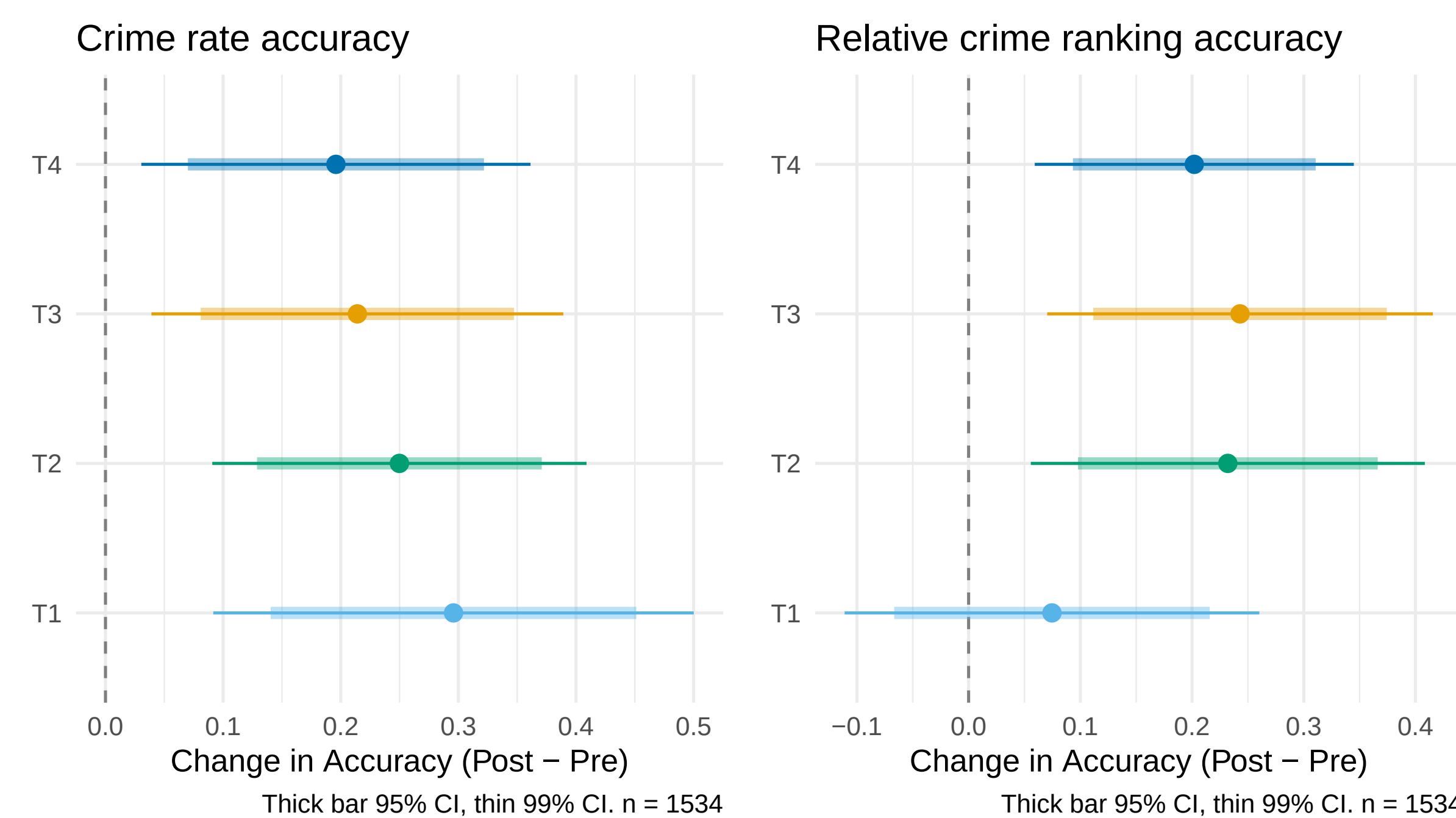
- $T_{ik} = 1$ indicates respondent i is assigned to arm k
- CG_i : crime rate perception gap, actual - prior, > 0 = “bad news”
- RG_i : peer ranking perception gap, actual - prior, > 0 = “bad news”

Example Treatment: Home vs Benchmark Municipalities



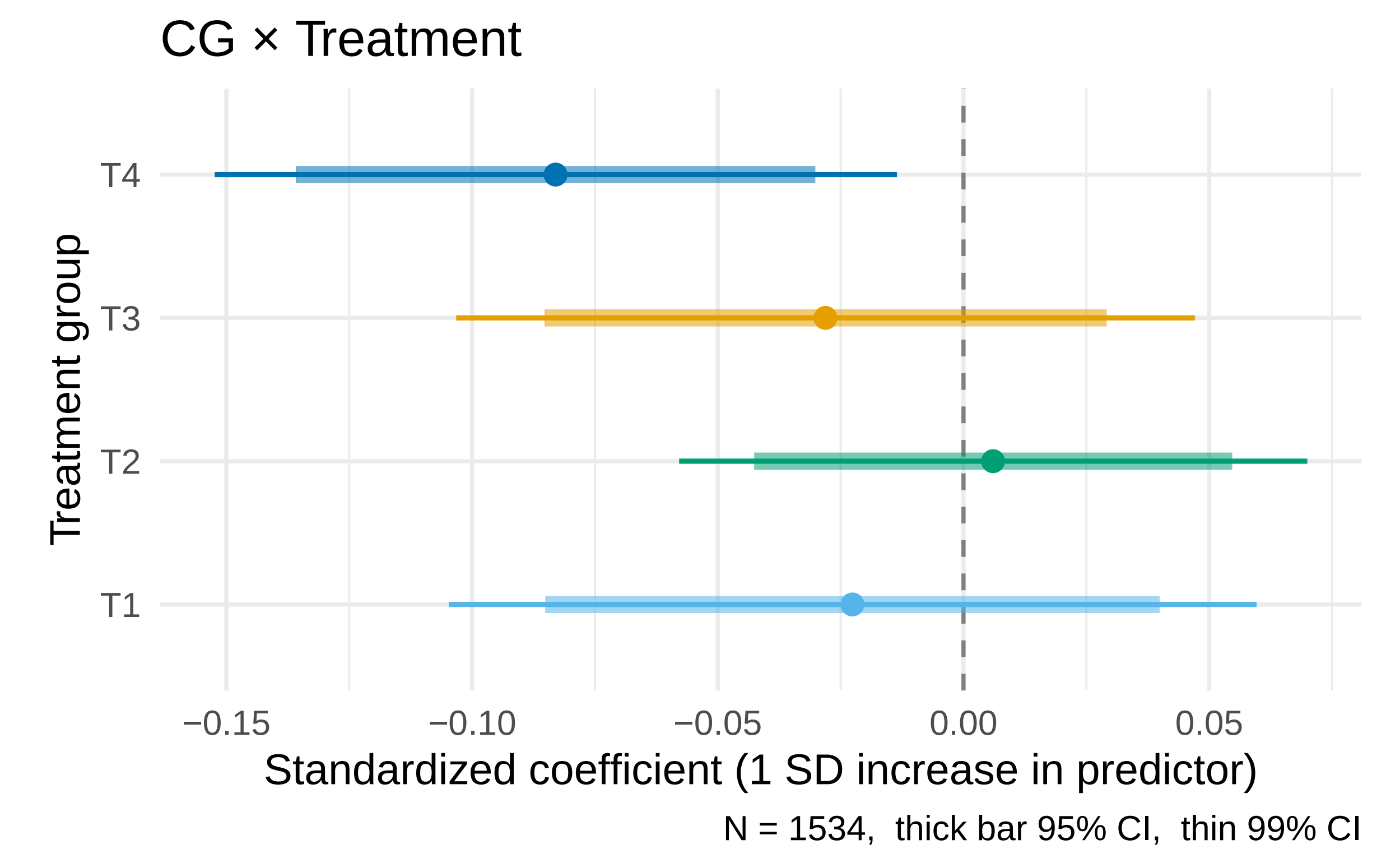
Information Updates

- Providing information leads to more accurate beliefs about crime



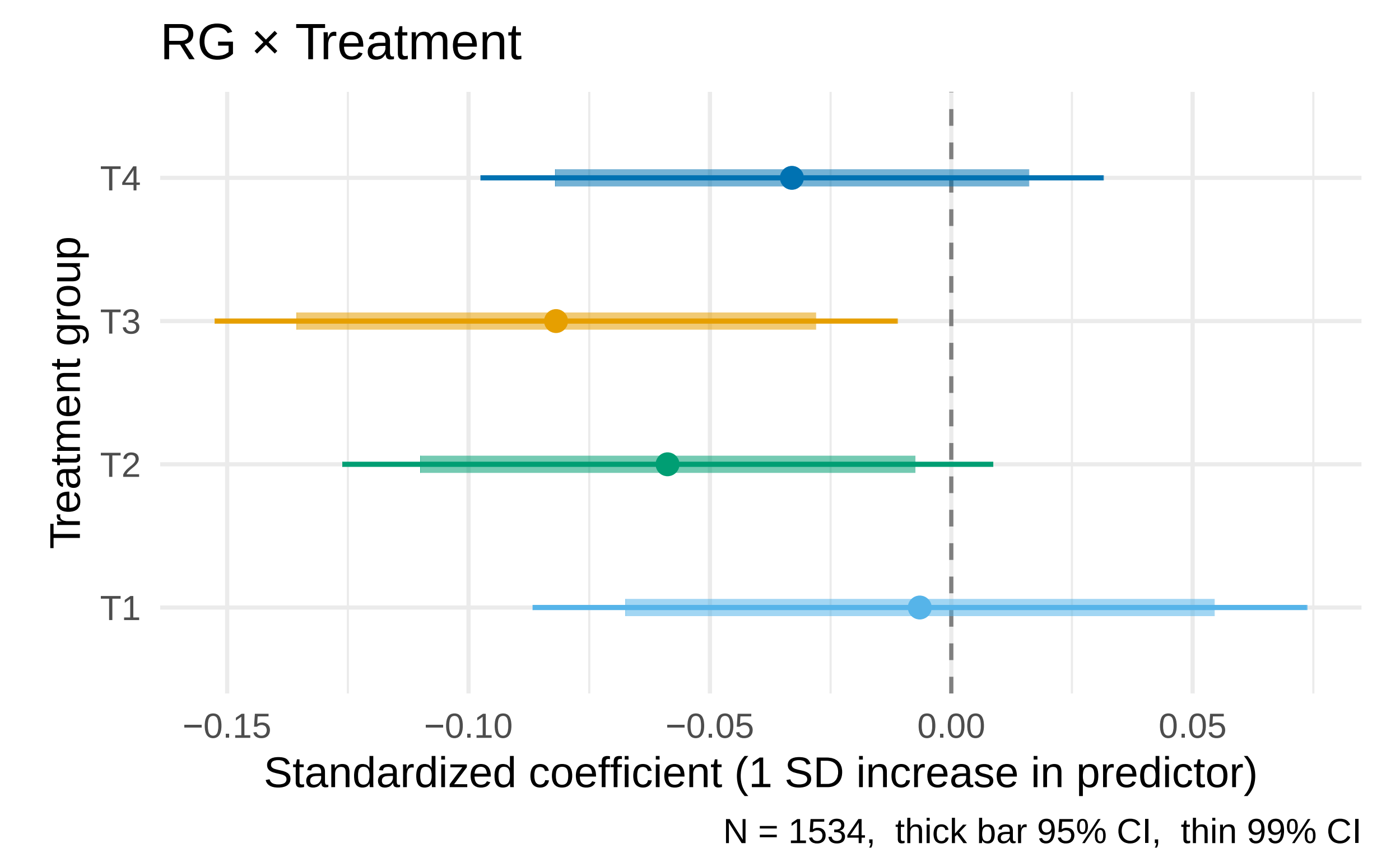
Absolute Crime-Rate Results

- Crime information alone (T1) does not change vote intention
- Bad news benchmarked by co-partisan comparison (T4) lowers vote intention for incumbent party
- Other benchmarks have similar (T3) or smaller (T2) effects than non-benchmarked information (T1)



Relative Crime Information Results

- Unfavorable out-partisan comparison (T3) lowers vote intention for incumbent party
- Non-partisan comparison (T2) also lowers vote intention ($p = 0.02$)
- Effect of co-partisan comparison (T4) on vote intention is attenuated and insignificant
- Difference between T3 and T4 is borderline significant ($p = 0.09$)



Implications

- People do respond to performance information, but how it's benchmarked determines whether it changes votes
- Same-party benchmarks help voters isolate the performance signal
- Opposition benchmarks work through relative standing vs. the challenger